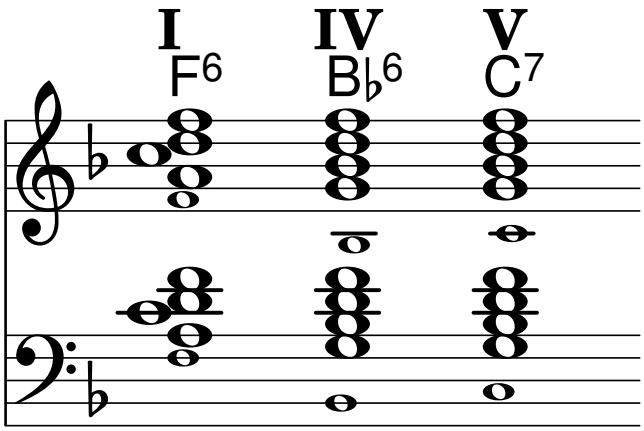
Blues Background Formula

Harmonizing improvised backgrounds over a 12-bar blues in concert F

How it works: one person makes up a background rhythm on the tonic; everyone repeats it.
Next time around each player picks *any* one note out of the formula and moves it with the chords of the blues.
Bottom to top: **I**^{6} = 3 5 6 1 · **IV**^{6} = 6 1 3 5 · **V**^{7} = the same four notes as IV (5 ♭7 9 11 over the V root).
The small bottom note of each stack is the root — tuba/sousaphone. Horns choose any of the four notes above it.

C (written in F)

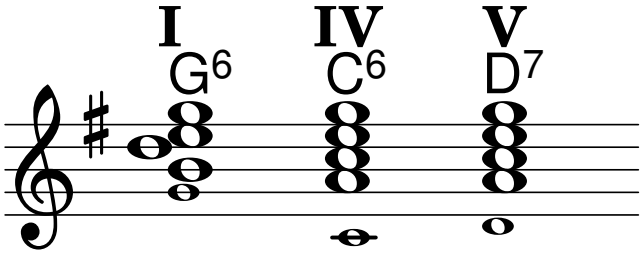
flute · bells · trombone · sousaphone — bass clef reads the lower staff



F **I**	F **I**	F **I**	F **I**
B♭ **IV**	B♭ **IV**	F **I**	F **I**
C^{7} **V**	B♭ **IV**	F **I**	F **I**

B♭ (written in G)

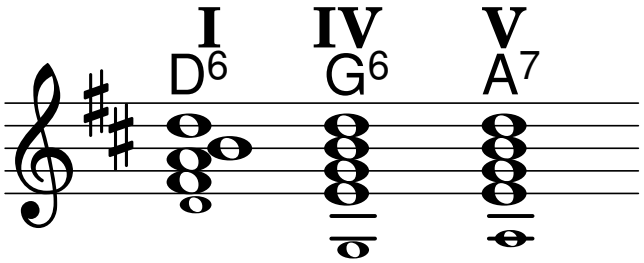
trumpet · clarinet · soprano & tenor sax · baritone · bass sax



G **I**	G **I**	G **I**	G **I**
C **IV**	C **IV**	G **I**	G **I**
D^{7} **V**	C **IV**	G **I**	G **I**

E♭ (written in D)

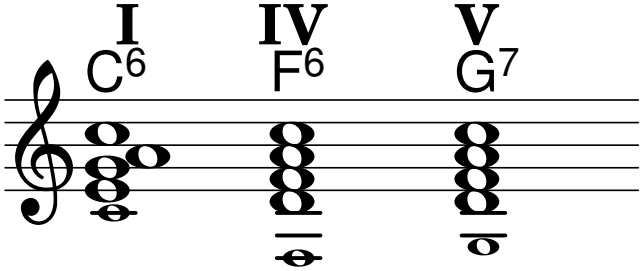
alto sax · bari sax



D **I**	D **I**	D **I**	D **I**
G **IV**	G **IV**	D **I**	D **I**
A^{7} **V**	G **IV**	D **I**	D **I**

F (written in C)

french horn



C **I**	C **I**	C **I**	C **I**
F **IV**	F **IV**	C **I**	C **I**
G^{7} **V**	F **IV**	C **I**	C **I**